Violet in cultures and traditions

Violet is a colour people have argued over for thousands of years. It cost a fortune, only a certain person could wear it, and it became a symbol of power as well as protest. Behind its reputation there are **more stories about money and power than about the colour itself**. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how violet is read in various **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, which use it as an image.

Violet in different cultures

Phoenicia

The Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon made purple dye from the mucus of sea snails. Sources give the start of production around 1200 BC, some even earlier. Thousands of snails were needed for one gram of dye. Heaps of empty shells have been found near Sidon and Tyre.

From work, patience and rarity. The colour was expensive because it was hard to make.

The price and meaning of the colour rest on **labour, not on the colour itself**.

Rome and Byzantium

Roman magistrates wore a toga with a purple border and a triumphing victor an entirely purple one. In the 4th century AD only the emperor could wear it. In Byzantium purple was the imperial colour and “born in the purple” meant the emperor's son born during his reign. After the fall of Constantinople in 1453 purple lost its imperial status, but sources differ on exactly when production ceased (one gives the year 1204).

From costly production and laws that decided who could wear what.

When few people may wear a colour, **it becomes a sign of power**. When anyone may wear it, it turns into fashion.

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The Catholic Church

In the Latin rite violet is the colour of penance. Priests wear it at confession, in Advent and in Lent. Pope Paul II decided in 1464 that cardinals would wear scarlet instead of purple, and the cheaper violet remained for bishops.

From the fact that a colour that was a sign of imperial power was turned in the church into a colour of humility and expectation.

Violet can be **both noble and humble at once**. It depends on the context in which you meet it.

The Mixtecs in Oaxaca

On the coast of Oaxaca violet was made for centuries from a sea snail that the Mixtecs call tishinda. Unlike in the Mediterranean the snail was **not killed**. The dye was gently "milked" from it, the liquid was pressed onto yarn and the snail was returned to the tidal zone. The Mixtecs travelled to the coast for it only at a certain time of year and took care not to interfere with its reproduction.

From an indigenous craft and knowledge of the rhythm of nature. In the 1980s the snails were damaged by a company that paid fishermen to collect them in bulk. Today the snail is threatened by coastal development and poaching, and efforts to breed it have so far been in vain.

The same colour that elsewhere cost the lives of snails was here **a colour that spares its source**. Beauty can also have a gentle form.

Violet in traditional systems

Each tradition looks at violet **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a guide to healing.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. In the table of the five phases (Huainanzi) violet is given as **an intermediate colour of water**, the basic colour of water being black. It can also be understood as a mixture of fire (red, heart) and water (blue, kidneys). The tradition speaks of cooperation between heart and kidneys. Fire is cooled by water and water is warmed by fire.

This is my reading in the spirit of the tradition, not a classical assignment. Violet is thus an image of balance between passion and calm, body and depth.

How it relates to the colour violet. When you have too much fire in your life (stress, hurry, tension), a violet with a cool tint helps calm. When you have too much water (tiredness, fear, cold), wine and plum add warmth.

What you can take from it. Ask which is closer to you. Do you need to calm down, or warm up? According to the answer choose a cooler (lavender) or a warmer (wine) violet.

And what if I asked you now?

"What do you miss more today, cooling down haste, or warming up tiredness?"

Two situations in which it could help you

When you have faced outwards all day. You answer, explain, decide and sense the needs of others. In the evening you no longer want another conversation, but your head carries on without an audience. If violet feels pleasant to you, it can be part of a place where you handle nothing more. A picture, a soft fabric or a flower. **One stimulus instead of many.** What can it bring you? A moment in which you do not have to react. A violet cushion next to a constantly ringing phone will have a hard shift.

When you have been withdrawn into yourself for a long time. More quieting may not be what you need. Maybe you want to open a window, go out, meet someone or get moving. Leave violet in the picture and invite something livelier into the surroundings. A yellow flower, a warmer textile or daylight. You are trying to recognise whether you need to rest or to rejoin life. **The answer does not have to be the same every time.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. **It is not a diagnosis** and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. In it a person is described by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. **Violet as a colour in its own right is not worked out in the classical texts.**

How it relates to the colour violet. Violet is made by mixing a warm red and a cool blue. That is why, according to modern interpretations, it can be adapted. **Light and cool calms, dark and wine-like warms.** Sources differ in the details, so take this as a direction, not a rule.

Pitta

This is how a purposeful, quick and thorough woman who flares up easily is described. Lavender and light violet calm her. The tradition recommends cooling colours.

- **Add lavender**
  Soft, cool, calming. In a bedroom or a work corner.
- **Add some cool**
  White and green, water, a walk by a river.

Vata

This is how an imaginative and quick but restless woman who is often cold is described. Cool light shades may be too cold for vata. A warmer plum and wine add warmth. **It is best to sense how you actually feel in it.**

- **Warmer shades**
  Wine, plum. Calm without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a calm, firm and patient woman who easily becomes heavy is described. Dark cold shades may deepen the heaviness. The tradition recommends **lively warm colours**.

- **Orchid and wine**
  Warmer and livelier, as an accent.
- **Add warmth**
  Orange or yellow as a counterweight. A scarf, a tablecloth.

What is useful for us is that Ayurveda works with qualities. Movement and stability, lightness and heaviness, warmth and cold. A lighter violet can feel airy, a dark velvety one dense and enveloping. Once exactly this is pleasant, another time already too much. From a particular dosha I therefore **do not make a prescription for a colour**. If your surroundings feel heavy at a time when you want to be active, try lighter surroundings or a smaller area.

An internet test will not reliably determine your dosha. If it interests you more, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not a treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe violet as a colour in its own right. He did, however, give colours for his four functions of the psyche. Thinking is white or blue and feeling is red. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his idea, not Jung's statement about violet.

How it relates to the colour violet. If thinking is blue and feeling is red, violet could be the colour of the moment when they meet. **Not reason against the heart, but reason with the heart.** A moment when you know that you feel something and can also name it.

What you can take from it. When you live only in your head, red (feeling) may do you good. When feeling overwhelms you and you do not know what to do with it, blue (talking it out, naming it) helps. Violet is an invitation to put it together.

Jung did not want colours to become a dictionary. He himself said that correspondences change with the person and culture. The same violet can be joy for one woman and sadness for another. **We always ask what it means for you.** Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui violet is **an intermediate colour of water** according to the classical table of the five phases. In some, especially Western, schools the south-east of the house map (bagua) is linked with wealth and abundance and violet and green are used for it. Schools differ on this, so take it as one possibility.

Violet is like lilac

A little gives a space depth and festivity, a handful turns it into theatre that quickly tires. The tradition takes it as a joining of fire and water, and so balances it with wood and greenery.

Simple tips

- **Start with one piece**
  For example a cushion or a flower (lavender, lilac) in a place where you will see it every day.
- **For every day**
  Soft shades (lavender, aubergine). Leave rich violet for small accents.
- **Natural materials**
  Combine it with wood, linen and wool.
- **Clothing**
  Violet in clothing is striking. When a rich one overwhelms you, try a lighter shade or a neutral accessory.
- **Festivity needs measure**
  Abundance does not have to mean six more cushions. Sometimes it is enough that you have somewhere comfortable to sit.
- **Try fabric first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it in the morning and in the evening.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Violet has always been the colour of kings.

TRUTH Tyrian purple was obtained from sea snails and was very expensive, which is why it became linked with power. Since 1856, when William Perkin discovered the first synthetic violet dye, it has also become a fashion for everyone.

MYTH Violet brings wealth.

TRUTH Some schools of feng shui put it in the south-east, the zone of abundance. Recommendations differ and the colour guarantees nothing.

MYTH Violet in the bedroom is ideal because it calms.

TRUTH A muted lilac or lila can be pleasant. A rich violet in a small dark room rather weighs down. How you fall asleep in it decides.

What to pair violet with

- **Cream and warm white**
  A lighter and softer whole.
- **Wood and linen**
  A more natural, less festive impression.
- **Green**
  It recalls a flower among leaves, just watch the proportion and richness.
- **Yellow or ochre**
  A striking lift that can be enough in a small area.
- **Pink**
  A softer or more sensual expression depending on the shades.
- **Grey and gold**
  Grey looks elegant. Gold gives festivity, but in excess it drowns out ordinary comfort.

Elements

- **Water and fire**
  Violet joins them. Take care that neither outweighs the other.
- **Wood and greenery**
  Plants and wood ground violet.
- **Metal**
  Gold and silver add shine, but in a small amount.
- **Earth**
  Clay and linen soften the festive impression.

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Feng shui room by room

What works, what to watch for and a simple tip.

Living room

What works. A violet cushion, throw or picture. It works as an accent, not as a whole wall. A plum armchair or a muted throw can give a light living room a striking centre.

What to watch for. In a small, poorly lit room with dark furniture, further deep areas can strengthen a heavy impression. Try a light fabric first or fewer decorations.

A simple tip. Velvet and wool add depth and warmth to violet, glossy satin makes it more festive and cooler. Matte linen calms it.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Violet can work in ceramics, textiles or on a smaller piece of furniture. Next to wood and a light base it looks distinctive.

What to watch for. Try a large dark area in a small kitchen first. I would not use violet light as the main lighting for food, because it changes its look.

A simple tip. Matte ceramics and glass in violet look light and playful. A glossy dark kitchen run, on the other hand, floods the room.

Bedroom

What works. Lavender or muted lilac can be pleasant in textiles. A deeper plum can feel intimate and sensual, if you perceive it that way. **Try it in fabric first**, you will easily tell whether it pleases you in the morning and in the evening, and you can put it away again.

What to watch for. Dark violet walls often feel heavy. If the whole feels cold to you, add a warmer neutral shade, wood or a soft material.

A simple tip. Cotton and linen in lavender feel airy, velvet in plum envelops you more. Notice how the textile feels under your hand as you fall asleep.

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Children's room

What works. A soft lavender can be calm. Violet can be a favourite, but it does not have to rule everything from ceiling to slippers. Try it in accessories that can be changed.

What to watch for. A rich violet for children often seems too serious. The colour alone does not decide whether a child will be calm, focused or sleep well. Light and the amount of things in the room matter too.

A simple tip. The child is the inhabitant of the room. Her own experience of the colour matters more than a general rule. A soft violet blanket or a plush toy often means more to children than the colour of a wall.

Study

What works. Violet supports creativity in small doses. It can be a personal choice for a corner where you read, design or paint.

What to watch for. One that is too rich tires the eyes. When its area disturbs you, move it out of the main view and give the workspace lighter surroundings.

A simple tip. Matte paper, wood or linen leave violet in the background. A glossy rich area highlights it, but can tire the eyes.

Hall and entrance

What works. The hallway is often the least lit room in a flat. Keep the walls light and put violet into small things. A flower, a picture or a rug. It is the first greeting that welcomes you at the door.

What to watch for. Dark shades lower the light. If your entrance feels gloomy, try better light or a lighter wall before another dark accessory.

A simple tip. A rug or hooks made of natural materials in soft violet welcome you. Glossy dark surfaces shrink the space even more.

Try asking yourself

“Why do I want violet at home? What should it bring me, calm, creativity or abundance?”

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